Acetaminophen

What you should know about using acetaminophen safely

What is Acetaminophen?

Acetaminophen is a drug that is used to:

- Temporarily relieve pain
- Temporarily reduce fever

Acetaminophen is found in hundreds of over-the-counter and prescription drugs. It may be the only active ingredient, or it may be combined with other active ingredients.

Acetaminophen is sold under many different brand names. In addition, abbreviations for acetaminophen – such as APAP, Acetaminoph, Acetaminop, Acetamin and Acetam – may be used on prescription labels. Outside of the United States, acetaminophen is commonly known as paracetamol.

Feedback

Acetaminophen is available in different forms:

- Tablets, including extended-release (long-acting) or chewable tablets
- Capsules
- Liquids
- Powders
- Suppositories (for rectal use)

Safe Use of Acetaminophen

Acetaminophen is safe and effective when used as directed.

To ensure safe use of acetaminophen:

- Always read the label of every over-the-counter and prescription drug before use.
- Know if you are taking drugs that contain acetaminophen. Both over-the-counter and prescription drugs may contain acetaminophen.
- Do not use more than one acetaminophen-containing product at a time. Acetaminophen is in many products. You could accidentally take too much if you use more than one product containing acetaminophen at a time.

- Follow dosing directions on the label. Make sure you understand:
  - How much you can take at one time (dose)
  - How many hours you must wait before taking another dose
  - How many times you can take it each day
  - When you should not take it and talk to your health care professional
- Never take more acetaminophen than what the label says, even if you still have fever or pain. Taking too much acetaminophen can cause liver failure and death.
- Ask your health care professional before use if you have liver disease.
- Be aware that severe liver damage may occur if you have three or more alcoholic drinks per day while using acetaminophen.
- Inform your health care professional of all drugs (prescription and over-the-counter), vitamins, and supplements you take. Ask your health care professional if any of your drugs contain acetaminophen, especially when receiving a new prescription.

The maximum total amount of acetaminophen taken in 24 hours should not be more than 4,000 mg for adults and children 12 years of age and older.

Ask your health care professional if you have questions about drugs that contain acetaminophen. If you think you have taken too much acetaminophen, get medical help or contact Poison Help at 1-800-222-1222 right away.



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